

Introduction to Professional Practices in IT

CS4001 – Professional Practices in IT

Asif Fazwani

Human Resources Issues

INTRODUCTION

- Employees are one of the most valuable resources in any organization, often more critical than physical or financial assets.
- Organizations must ensure they have the right mix of **skills, qualifications, and experience** among staff to effectively use their other assets.

INTRODUCTION

- Staffing must be efficient, too many employees create waste, while too few can reduce productivity. HR policies must also comply with labor laws and regulations.
- Recruiting and training new employees is costly, so organisations aim to retain talent and reduce turnover.

THE LEGAL CONTEXT

- Human Resource Management (HRM) is shaped by a complex network of laws primarily designed to **protect employees' rights**, since employers often hold more power.
- UK companies must comply with laws like the **Employment Rights Act 1996** and updates to the **Equality Act 2010**, ensuring fair treatment in hiring, pay, and dismissal.

THE LEGAL CONTEXT

Constantly Changing Legislation

- Employment law is **dynamic**, frequent updates reflect changing political priorities, economic conditions, and social attitudes.
- **Example:** In 2024–2025, UK policymakers discussed “**right to disconnect**” laws, following similar moves in France and Ireland, reflecting the need to balance remote work with employee well-being.

THE LEGAL CONTEXT

Political Influence on Employment Law

- Employment law is often a **political battleground**, with Conservative and Labour governments historically taking different approaches.
- **Example: Modern debates (2025):** The Labour Party has proposed strengthening **workers' rights to flexible working** and limiting **zero-hour contracts**, showing how politics still shapes HR practice

Responsibilities of the HR department

- Ensuring that recruitment, selection and promotion
- Procedures comply with anti-discrimination legislation
- Overseeing staff training and development
- Setting up and monitoring remuneration and appraisal procedures
- Administering dismissal and redundancy procedures
- Handling contracts of employment
- Engaging in workforce planning
- Rights and advising management of what the organization must do to comply with it
- Overseeing health and safety

RECRUITMENT AND SELECTION

- Human resources managers often make a distinction between the two terms recruitment and selection, using recruitment is to mean soliciting applications and selection is to mean selecting the applicants to whom offers will be made.
- Selection is kept in the hands of the employer, although a member of the recruitment agency staff may sometimes be invited to advise.

SELECTION TOOLS

- A series of **one-to-one interviews** with senior management and senior technical staff.
- Interview by a panel: A **number of interviewers** are involved. This technique is widely used, particularly in the public sector. It tends to favour applicants who are smooth talkers. It is unreliable.
- **Psychometric tests:** These are of three types. **Ability tests** measure an individual's ability in a general area, such as verbal or numerical skills. **Aptitude tests** measure a person's potential to learn the skills needed for a job. **Personality tests** attempt to assess the characteristics of a person that significantly affect how they behave in their relationships with other people.
- **Situational assessment:** Real time situations are given to shortlisted candidates. Its most expensive and used in military officers' selection.
- **Task assessment:** Candidates are asked to carry out some of the tasks that they will be required to do in the job. People usually are able to do small tasks but unable to do large task so this is unfavorable.

STAFF TRAINING AND DEVELOPMENT

- Training and development encompasses three main activities: **training, education, and development.**
- It is a function concerned with organizational activity aimed at bettering the performance of individuals and groups in the organization. It has been known by several names, including "Human Resource Development", "Human Capital Development" and "Learning and Development".
- Staff training and development are of particular importance in high technology companies, where failure in this respect can threaten the company's performance.
- It is unfortunate that, when money is tight, it is often the first thing to be cut.

REMUNERATION POLICIES AND JOB EVALUATION

- Remuneration is the compensation that one receives in exchange for the work or services performed. Typically, this consists of monetary rewards, also called wages or salaries. Several complementary benefits, however, are increasingly popular remuneration mechanisms.
- Remuneration” includes **total compensation** salary plus benefits such as bonuses, health insurance, stock options, company cars, or flexible work perks.

Example

- Google offers a mix of salary, equity shares, and wellness benefits like mental health days and hybrid-work allowances to retain employees in competitive markets.
- Many startups offer stock options as part of remuneration to attract talent when cash flow is limited.

REMUNERATION POLICIES

- Differences in pay can cause **employee dissatisfaction**, especially if workers feel the system is unfair or non-transparent.

Example:

- In 2024, the **BBC** faced criticism over gender pay disparities, which led to greater scrutiny of pay transparency in UK media organizations.
- Modern HR systems now use **pay audits** to identify and address such inequalities.

APPRAISAL SCHEMES

- Appraisal (Performance appraisal) is a method by which the job performance of an employee is documented and evaluated.
- Appraisal schemes usually involve an appraiser and an appraisee meeting.
- Regularly (every six months, every year, even every two years) to discuss the employee's performance and career development under several headings.
- The result is a report signed by both parties; if they cannot agree on certain points this will be recorded in the report.

APPRAISAL SCHEMES

- The person responsible for undertaking an appraisal of an employee (the appraisee). The appraiser is often the employee's line manager since he or she is thought to have the best knowledge of the employee's performance, attitude, and competency.

APPRAISAL SCHEMES

- Appraisals derive from the idea of Management by Objectives (MBO). MBOs were developed by Peter Drucker, one of the most distinguished management theorists, in the 1970s, and it rapidly became popular in the industry. It was seized on by the government in the 1980s as a way of dealing with what they saw as poor performance and indolence in many state-funded jobs.
- The essence of MBO is that managers and their subordinates agree on a set of objectives for the subordinate to achieve over the next period, typically six months. These objectives should be precise, objectively verifiable, and, ideally, quantifiable.

REDUNDANCY and DISMISSAL

- Redundancy is a form of termination caused by changes in the business, while dismissal is a form of termination caused by employee misconduct or poor performance.
- Unfair dismissal

Reasons justifying dismissal

- Lack of capability
- Misconduct
- Breach of the law
- Redundancy

Unfair dismissal vs wrongful dismissal

- Dismissal of an employee without valid reasons is unfair.
- A fair dismissal of an employee but violating a contract is wrongful dismissal

Take overs and outsourcing

- Employees employed by the previous employer when the undertaking changes hands automatically become employees of the new employer on the same terms and conditions. It is as if their contracts of employment had originally been made with the new employer. Thus, employees' continuity of employment is preserved, as are their terms and conditions of employment under their contracts of employment (except for certain occupational pension rights).
- Representatives of employees affected have a right to be informed about the transfer. They must also be consulted about any measures which the old or new employer envisages taking concerning affected employees.

HUMAN RESOURCE PLANNING

- If the human resources department is to ensure that the organization always has available the staff it needs, it must be able to forecast the needs some time ahead.

In a software house, there are three inputs to the human resource planning process:

- Human resource plans from existing projects
- Sales forecasts
- Forecasts of the likely staff losses in the coming months

JOB DESIGN

Job rotation: Job rotation, that is, rotating staff through a series of jobs, is the most obvious way of preventing employees from becoming bored with a very narrow and specialized task.

Job enlargement: Job enlargement means increasing the scope of a job through extending the range of its job duties and responsibilities generally within the same level and periphery. Job enlargement involves combining various activities at the same level in the organization and adding them to the existing job

Job enrichment: Job enrichment can be described as a medium through which management can motivate self-driven employees by assigning them additional responsibilities normally reserved for higher-level employees. By doing this, employees feel like their work has meaning and is important to the company